TECHNOLOGY HAS TRANSFORMED THE VERY LANDSCAPE IN WHICH our conversations around sexuality were once situated. In less than a decade, the ground beneath our feet has shifted beyond belief. On the one hand, the rise of online dating apps has normalised casual sexual encounters, smashed quaint notions of propriety, widened the acceptance of non-binary and LGBTQ+ identities and, operating under the logic of the market, has paved the way for self-objectification, self-commodification and instant gratification. On the other hand, the same advances have enabled the proliferation of misogynistic right-wing groups, often masquerading as men's rights groups; they have also increased the feeling of alienation even as there is a state of abundance, fuelled anxieties, unrealistic expectations and addiction to pornography and, worse of all, made women the victims of sextortion, revenge porn and cyber-bullying. In some ways, these are two sides of the same coin—the effects of, and pushback against, liberal attitudes in India.

The progressive frame of mind that exists among the vast majority of young people today survives within a certain bubble of privilege, class-caste location, urban/university-centricity. Outside this cocoon, old habits die hard. The reason for such change to not catch on and spread like wildfire through the body of our nation is that we are a deeply unequal, undemocratic society. Writing about an ideal society, Dr Ambedkar observed that it "should be mobile, should be full of channels for conveying a change taking place in one part to other parts". Calling this process of conscious communication and sharing of varied interests "social endosmosis", Dr Ambedkar underlined that this was fraternity, "only another name for democracy". Sadly, in our less-than-ideal society, a positive change taking place in one part of society is only met with stiff resistance when it is conveyed to other, socially more conservative sections deeply invested in upholding the patriarchal status quo. In fact, when these notions reach them and they realise that getting laid is as easy as swiping right, they counter it through scare-mongering, homophobia, transphobia and, most of all, a demographic paranoia that finds an outlet in propagandist red flags such as 'love jihad'. Forget about the transmission of these changes from starkly different parts of society—today's younger generation is often constrained to conceal several aspects of their lives, their sexual identities and their sexual orientation from their own parents.

DEBATES ON SEXUALITY HAVE HUGE SILENCES ON VIOLENCE BY STATES, INDIVIDUALS

For the above reasons, I want to argue that just as discussions around sexuality in India cannot be divorced from the direction in which they are taken forward by technological innovations, we must also ground our understanding on this by getting in touch with our cultural, social and political history. This means that we do not take our hard-won freedoms for granted. This means that we have to be prepared to face criticism for every act of disruption that threatens the old order of things: whether we are writing about female sexual desire, narrating an anecdote about a Bumble date, fighting for the right to live together, or reclaiming our right to fall in love across caste, class and religious lines.

One of the pitfalls of liberal-speak on sexuality is that an awareness of the fraught and precious nature of the few avenues open to hosting such discussions makes people censor and constrain themselves into safe zones. The few women who openly speak about these are hounded, branded and trolled. Even those who address sexuality and female desire do not have the luxury of making noise about how fascist regimes reinforce cis-heterosexual relationships. Conversations about sexuality have huge silences and blanks on violence, perpetuated by both individuals and states. Last year, 21 million Indian women disappeared from the workforce, the sharpest plummet ever. It underlines the bitter truth that we are being forced to become wives and stay-at-home mothers. How does this connect with agency, autonomy, mobility and the exercise of female sexual desire?

It does not end here. Even as online dating apps become popular, the struggle to, say, find oral and emergency contraceptives is an uphill task, and often an exercise in public humiliation. How do we deal with this hypocrisy, and how do we hold institutions to account for this gap between word and deed? Sexuality and female desire are an entry point into setting right several ills in our society, and I feel that these discussions should not be viewed as an end in itself. ■

Meena Kandasamy is a poet, author, translator and activist